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YOUNG STARS AND OLD LEGENDS SHINE

Liverpool and Arsenal delivered an anti-climactic duel while Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo impressed with **strong performances** in the World Cup qualifiers.

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The Premier League witnessed an early clash between two teams heavily tipped to be in the title race at the end of the season. Arne Slot's Liverpool and Mikel Arteta's Arsenal battled it out in front of a boisterous Anfield crowd. With neutrals expecting a goal fest given the sharp attacking line-ups of both teams, the result was anti-climactic. Liverpool edged past Arsenal with a 1-0 win courtesy of a smooth free kick by Dominik Szoboszlai in the 83rd minute. The Gunners, who had 11 shots at goal but managed only one on target, garnered widespread criticism for their reserved approach.

Manchester United legend and former goalkeeper Peter Schmeichel, when asked to comment on the game, said: "I have never in my life, ever, wanted a team to win

a game of football more than Liverpool today. Arsenal brings an ugly brand of football to our game. Arteta... let your team play football... You need two teams to give a good game of football, and there is only one team trying to play football, and that's Liverpool. I don't want to insult Arsenal, but their brand of football is so annoying to watch. It's designed to exploit opponents while watching for set pieces."

Liverpool's good fortune continued as the long-drawn transfer saga involving Alexander Isak came to an end, with the Swedish striker making a British-record £125m move to the

Heavyweight clash: Liverpool players celebrate with Dominik Szoboszlai whose last-gasp free kick sealed a crucial win against Arsenal. REUTERS

